

Tips & Tricks

SECRETS THAT KEEP YOU AHEAD IN THE RACE

TIPS

Windows XP
Windows Games
Internet Explorer
Firefox 2

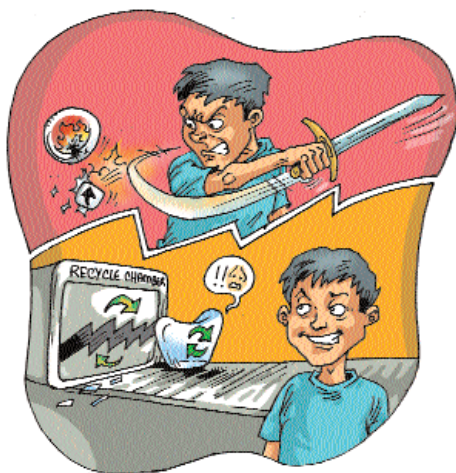
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30 MINUTES EXPERT

Play Anything

66

WINDOWS



Illustrations Harsho Mohan Chatterjee

Wherever the Registry Editor is mentioned in the following, you will need to go to **Start > Run**, type in “regedit” and press [Enter]. You also need to remember that editing the Windows Registry can be dangerous, and if not done right, might require you to format and re-install Windows to get your system working again. Ideally, you should back up your Registry before making any changes to it.



Open Without?

When you right-click on a file, one of the options you see is “Open With”. These usually contain what Windows thinks are valid programs to open particular file types. Now, sometimes, when you have bad installers or

uninstallers, some programs leave their mark on this context menu. Basically, if you want to clean out this long list of junk that accumulates here, you have to edit the Registry.

Open the Registry Editor and navigate to **HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Explorer\FileExts**

Now, for example, if you have to remove programs from the Open With menu for AVI files, find the extension on the left that corresponds to AVI files and click on the “+” sign to expand it and find the “OpenWithList” key. In the right pane you should see a list of programs, such as “wmplayer.exe”, “notepad.exe”, “mplayer.exe”, etc. Select the ones you don’t want and delete them.

Next, navigate to **HKEY_CLASSES_ROOT** and find the same extension. Again, navigate to “OpenWithList” and delete the unwanted programs. This key is where Windows reads from when using the All Users profile. Now you will only see the programs that you want in the Open With list... well, most of the time; the problem is that Windows also reads the Open With list from another registry key: **HKEY_CLASSES_ROOT\SystemFileAssociations**

Here’s where it reads the default Open With list from, but we strongly advise you against changing it because it might affect multiple file types.



Show Desktop Not Showing

Sometimes, we accidentally delete the Show Desktop icon in the Quick Launch menu. You can manually

recreate it by creating a file called “Show Desktop.scf”. Open Notepad, and type in the following:

[Shell]

Command=2

IconFile=explorer.exe,3

[Taskbar]

Command=ToggleDesktop

Save this file as “Show Desktop.scf” by selecting the “Save as” type as All Files—to prevent the file being saved as “Show Desktop.scf.txt”.

Now all you have to do is drag this file to the Quick Launch toolbar and your Show Desktop icon is restored.

Another way is to use the Regsvr32 command. Go to **Start > Run** and type in “regsvr32 /n /i:U shell32.dll”. This should restore the Show Desktop icon.



Save Disk Space

Windows XP, after Service Pack 1, keeps uninstall information for all updates in the C:\Windows folder. These appear as \$NTUninstall...

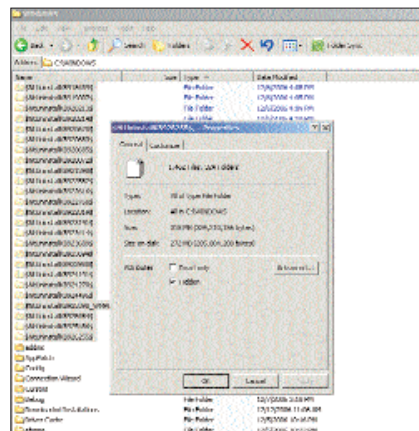
Depending on how many updates you’ve installed, you might have anywhere from a couple to a couple of dozen of these folders. In order to save some disk space, you can delete these folders. Doing this does not uninstall the updates, but will make sure that you cannot uninstall them later—though why someone would want to uninstall security fixes is something we can’t understand at all anyway.

In case you do want to know exactly what uninstaller you’re deleting, you can go to <http://support.microsoft.com/?kbid=<###>>, where <###> is the number listed in the name of the folder you are deleting—remember, don’t add the text “\$NTUninstallKB”, just the number after the prefix.

Once you’re satisfied, just select the folder(s) and press [Shift] + [Delete].

Now, there are two ways in which to remove their references from the Add/Remove Programs list.

Open the Registry Editor and



Here’s the perfect example of wasted space: 272 MB of update uninstallers!